BOOKS

Star-Crossed Actors

Smita Banerjee's Modernities and the Popular Melodrama: The Suchitra-Uttam Yug *examines the most successful pairing in Bengali cinema*

MODERNITIES AND THE POPULAR MELODRAMA:
The Suchitra-Uttam Yug in Bengali Cinema
by Smita Banerjee
ORIENT BLACKSWAN
₹1,045; 312 pages



The story goes that a Bengali director wanted to remake the Hindi hit *Dosti* (1962), a tale of two young boys, one blind and one lame. "Who will you cast," asked a friend, "Uttam and Suchitra?" The joke serves as a great indicator, especially for the non-Bengali cinema lover, of the power of this screen couple who became "metonyms for love and modern romance". Beginning with 22

BOOKS

HERO WORSHIP

Mukesh Manjunath's funny and informative book explains how and why **Telugu screen deities** come into existence

It's rare to find good personal writing in cinema books, but Mukesh Manjunath's *The Age of Heroes*—about the cult of 'heroes' in Telugu cinema, and how the relationship between superstar/ deity and adoring fan plays out across such faultlines as caste, class and gender—is a fine exception. In one passage, he mentions his grandmother's obsession with the superstar N.T. Rama Rao, whom she never saw in person. The story culminates in the author realising why he was her favourite grandchild—because he was born on NTR's birthday.

Many may scoff at such a story, but these are real, nourishing aspects of the cinema-viewer bond. South India has had divinities who began as screen icons and later moved on to politics, in the process representing many important things to people. Manjunath examines this complex story as it has unfolded in the past seven decades. He discusses the lingual differences and post-Independence histories of the Telugu-speaking regions, starting with the formation of Andhra Pradesh in the 1950s, and the effect of folk-tales on popular cinema. He tries to understand what superfans mean when they say things like "there is an aura around Chiranjeevi". There